

Jack Dorsey's best tech ideas

Why simplicity and open systems
keep winning

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A founder is not a job, it's a role, an attitude. And it's something that can happen again and again and again, and in fact it has to happen again and again and again, otherwise we would not move forward.

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There is a certain type of builder in Silicon Valley who gets bored the moment something works. They hand it off, walk away, and start tearing at the next thing.

Jack Dorsey is not exactly that. He is the rarer kind: someone who keeps building the same idea over and over, just at a different layer of the stack each time. Twitter, Block, Bitchat. Three companies, three radically different contexts, one obsession running beneath all of them like a wire. The belief that the most powerful systems are the ones with the fewest moving parts, the ones that do not ask for your permission, your phone number, your identity, or your trust in a corporation to function. Dorsey has never been a showman in the Jobs mould or a strategist in the Gates mould. He is something quieter and arguably more radical: a protocol thinker who keeps building products as proof of concepts for a future where infrastructure belongs to no one. Every other leader in this series had one signature idea that defined their company. Dorsey has one signature idea that he keeps rebuilding from scratch, each time stripping away another layer of institutional dependency.

Twitter: The constraint was the product

In 2006 when Twitter first went live, the 140-character limitation was not an exercise in philosophy but more of a happy accident. It was based on SMS limitations whereby 160 characters was the ceiling with 20 set aside for the username. However, Dorsey and his founding partners did one thing that many might not have expected, which was to keep it as a restriction even after it was no longer necessary since he and his partners knew what it enabled.

Forced brevity forces clarity of thought. The 140-character restriction is not just about truncating information but thinking before immortalising some thought into writing on the web. Twitter became the platform where a single tweet got the power to move markets, deliver breaking news before any other channel of communication could and give voice to those who didn't previously have one. This was no coincidence but the power of eliminating friction from publishing. Prior to Twitter, publishing something on the internet involved having a blog or at least an account on someone else's platform with title